

Free Legal Help & Legal Aid

Need a lawyer but can't afford one? Free legal aid helps with everyday civil problems — housing, family, benefits, and more. Below are the trusted national starting points. Tick the box once you've checked each one.

⚠ BEFORE YOU START

Legal aid covers civil (non-criminal) matters like eviction, custody, and benefits. Help is free if you qualify, usually by income. For criminal charges, you have the right to a public defender — ask the court.

1 Find Legal Aid Near You

The main tools to find free legal help in your area.

- ☐ **LawHelp.org**
Find free legal aid programs and plain-language legal information for your state.
→ www.lawhelp.org
- ☐ **Legal Services Corporation — Find Legal Aid**
The federal directory of local legal aid offices nationwide.
→ www.lsc.gov/about-lsc/what-legal-aid/get-legal-help

2 Free Legal Answers & Advice

Get questions answered by volunteer lawyers for free.

- ☐ **ABA Free Legal Answers**
Ask a civil legal question online and get a free answer from a volunteer lawyer.
→ www.freelegalanswers.org
- ☐ **211 — Local Legal Help**
Call or search to find legal aid and self-help resources nearby.
→ www.211.org or dial 211

3 Help Yourself in Court

Free tools if you must represent yourself.

- ☐ **Court Self-Help Centers**
Many courts offer free workshops, forms, and help for people without a lawyer. Check your state court's website.
→ **Search your state court + 'self-help center'**
- ☐ **Law School Legal Clinics**
Law students, supervised by professors, offer free legal help in many areas.
→ **Search your area + 'law school legal clinic'**

4 Special Protections

Extra help for survivors and crime victims.

☐ Domestic Violence Legal Help

Legal aid can help with protective orders, custody, and divorce — regardless of immigration status.

→ www.thehotline.org 1-800-799-7233

⚠ WATCH OUT FOR

Real legal aid is free or low-cost — never pay a large upfront fee to a “legal service” that isn’t a recognized nonprofit. Be cautious of non-lawyers charging to fill out legal forms.

★ A TIP THAT HELPS

Apply to legal aid as early as possible — offices have limited capacity and legal deadlines are strict. Even if one office can’t take your case, they often refer you to someone who can.

NEED HELP WHERE YOU LIVE?

Need help where you live?

This guide covers national starting points. For legal aid offices and self-help centers near you, use the personalized AI search or ask in the Questions area, and we’ll help you find them.

MY NOTES — WHO I CALLED, WHEN, AND WHAT THEY SAID
